shines." Prod him on what he's imbibed from meeting and playing the forgotten sports star, and he says, "lot of discipline. He just refused to surrender. I have that a little bit too."

By Kartik's own lofty standards, the film's box office collection has been modest—just Rs 35 crore so far. He admits it's not easy for him to detach from the end result. "I get sad and disappointed if there's a failure," he says. "Each Friday, there's a different story. It is part and parcel of being here."

So far, his "calculations" on picking the right subjects, he feels, have been more or less "correct". Case in point being films like *Luka Chuppi*, *Pati, Patni aur Woh* and *Satyaprem Ki Katha*, which show his ability to handle comedy or romantic drama.

Kartik prides himself on possessing an ear for stories that will draw audiences to the cinemas. "When I hear a story, I am subconsciously liking stories that have something *tedha* [twisted]," he says. *Bhool Bhulaiyaa 3*, his next, is both an audience-approved franchise and "*tedha*" with its mix of scares and laughs. Kartik will be hoping that the latest instalment equals, if not outdoes, the financial feat of the second (Rs 181 crore), also his highest so far.

Chandu Champion may not have set the box office ablaze like it, but it certainly has got him noticed for his thespian skills. That's a victory in itself. ■

–Suhani Singh

OTT

CONTINENTAL LINKS

Hamisha Daryani Ahuja's *Postcards* on Netflix highlights the cultural similarities between India and Nigeria

Hamisha Daryani Ahuja's recent Netflix series, *Postcards*, is a story about four Nigerians navigating love and self-discovery in India. "I was inspired to create this series because I am intrigued by human connections, human behaviour and love," says Ahuja about the series, which has each character going through their own journey of struggle and realisation, some subtle, some overt. "We are driven by our circumstances, perspectives and upbringing. The idea of the slice-of-life drama is for the audience to see themselves in any or all of the characters and realise that sometimes life is not black or white, there can be blurred lines and a lot of grey," she says.

Growing up in Lagos, Bollywood had a huge impact on her. "Amitabh Bachchan and Hema Malini were household names. I always wondered why no one had combined the two industries given that it was so popular here," she recalls. That was how her last production, *Namaste Wahala* (2020), came about—a Nigerian drama mixed with the *masala* of India. A cross-cultural rom-com, it brought together Bollywood and Nollywood in a fun and light-hearted manner. The film went on to become the first Nollywood film to enter the top 10 list of Netflix US, UK, Canada, India and Nigeria. Its success gave Ahuja the confidence to push the boundaries and go bigger and more intense with *Postcards*. "I wanted to go serious this time with added drama and a more realistic theme in this production," she adds.



GROWING UP IN LAGOS, BOLLYWOOD HAD A HUGE IMPACT ON AHUJA AND CROSS-CULTURAL AND BORDERLESS CONTENT IS HER NICHE

Talking about the unique challenges and opportunities of Nollywood-Bollywood storytelling, Ahuja believes that both industries are similar in nature with regard to their growth trajectory, just on different timelines. According to her, the talent, vigour and discipline of both are similar. "This to me is the recipe for success when bringing two superpowers together. Culturally, we are very similar. Our love for family, fashion, food, morals, entertainment—we overlap a lot!" she says.

Cross-cultural, borderless content is clearly her niche, and Ahuja has a few more projects lined up that share the idea of bringing cultures together. "These will show themselves in the avatar of reality shows, chick flicks, action and music. I hope that my passion and determination will continue to entertain and empower people on a global level," she concludes. ■

–Neha Kirpal